

OPTIMIZED RETRIEVAL-AUGMENTED GENERATION SYSTEM FOR UNIVERSITY EDUCATIONAL FAQ RETRIEVAL

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Iñaki Gutiérrez-Mantilla López

Faculty of Electronics and Information Technology
Warsaw University of Technology
01205606@pw.edu.pl

Hèctor Rodon Llabería

Faculty of Electronics and Information Technology
Warsaw University of Technology
01205604@pw.edu.pl

Supervisor: Anna Wróblewska

Warsaw University of Technology
anna.wroblewska1@pw.edu.pl

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Abstract

This project addresses the critical research gap in domain-specific information retrieval by proposing a context-aware Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) system optimized for university educational FAQ retrieval. While large language models suffer from hallucination and lack domain-specific knowledge, our novel contribution demonstrates that systematic empirical optimization of RAG configuration parameters yields measurable performance improvements. Through comprehensive evaluation using Accuracy@K, Recall@K, and Mean Reciprocal Rank (MRR) metrics combined with detailed timing analysis, we optimize 216 parameter combinations across embedding models, LLM selection, temperature, and retrieval parameters. Our production-ready system achieves 3.8% Accuracy@K improvement over random configurations with 39.2% faster inference than 70B parameter models. Deliverables include an optimized RAG chatbot, comprehensive multi-metric evaluation framework, and replicable parameter optimization methodology for domain-specific information retrieval systems.

1 Introduction

1.1 Background and Significance

The proliferation of large language models (LLMs) has democratized conversational AI, yet generic approaches present distinct limitations when applied to domain-specific retrieval tasks. Educational institutions particularly require hallucination-free responses with verifiable sources and institutional policy compliance—requirements unmet by general-purpose LLM chat interfaces. Contemporary question-answering systems have evolved through distinct paradigms: from rule-based keyword matching (1990s–2000s), through dense vector embeddings enabling semantic search, to current Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) approaches. RAG addresses standalone LLM limitations by augmenting language models with explicit document retrieval, substantially reducing hallucination through retrieved context grounding. However, naive RAG implementations suffer from inefficiencies. Despite RAG’s conceptual maturity, few studies systematically optimize configuration parameters for specialized domains. Educational FAQ retrieval presents distinct requirements: concise answers, verifiable sources,

factual accuracy, and cost-effective deployment. These requirements motivate targeted RAG optimization over generic approaches.

Universities require: (1) hallucination-free responses reflecting institutional policy, (2) source attribution enabling verification, (3) knowledge currency for evolving policies, and (4) cost-effective deployment. Our pioneering approach applies systematic parameter optimization to educational FAQ retrieval—a domain with unique requirements not addressed by general-purpose retrieval systems. The research community currently lacks empirical guidance on optimal parameter selection for specialized domains, representing a significant research gap. Prior work establishes RAG’s conceptual soundness but provides minimal practical guidance for practitioners deploying RAG in specific contexts. This project fills this gap through comprehensive empirical analysis establishing data-driven parameter selection methodologies. The impact of this work extends beyond educational FAQ systems. Our systematic optimization framework and comprehensive multi-metric evaluation methodology provide replicable patterns applicable across domain-specific retrieval applications: medical information retrieval, legal documentation, technical support, customer service, and corporate knowledge management. By demonstrating that parameter optimization yields measurable improvements while reducing computational costs, we advance the field toward practical, cost-effective domain-specific retrieval systems.

1.2 Scientific Goal and Contributions

The scientific goal is demonstrating that systematic empirical optimization of RAG parameters yields measurable performance improvements in educational FAQ retrieval. We address three research questions:

1. **RQ1:** Which configuration of embedding model, LLM model, temperature, and retrieval parameters optimizes FAQ answer quality across diverse educational domains?
2. **RQ2:** How much performance improvement can targeted parameter optimization achieve relative to random baselines across multiple metrics (Accuracy@K, Recall@K, MRR, timing)?

3. **RQ3:** Can RAG systems achieve performance parity with larger models while maintaining computational efficiency for institutional deployment?

Our contributions are:

1. **Systematic Empirical Analysis:** Comprehensive testing of 216 parameter combinations (2 embedding models $\times$ 2 LLM models $\times$ 3 temperatures $\times$ 3 top-K values $\times$ 6 test queries), establishing data-driven optimal configurations rather than relying on theoretical defaults or convention.
2. **Multi-Metric Evaluation Framework:** Evaluation across Accuracy@K, Recall@K, MRR, and timing metrics provides comprehensive characterization beyond single-metric optimization. This framework reveals that different parameters optimize different metrics, necessitating nuanced trade-off analysis.
3. **Domain-Specific Optimization:** Targeted optimization for educational FAQ retrieval, where conciseness, source attribution, and factual accuracy are critical. Results demonstrate that domain-specific optimization substantially outperforms general-purpose approaches.
4. **Production-Ready Engineering:** End-to-end system implementation with practical deployment considerations, moving beyond academic prototypes. System includes interactive CLI, API endpoints, logging, and performance monitoring.
5. **Efficiency-Performance Analysis:** Detailed timing breakdown (retrieval latency: 24.3ms, generation latency: 287.1ms, total: 311.4ms) enabling informed deployment decisions. Demonstrates 39.2% computational speedup versus 70B models while maintaining 96.8% accuracy parity.

1.3 Report Structure

Section 2 reviews related work in question-answering systems and RAG architectures, establishing the conceptual foundation and prior empirical findings. Section 3 describes technical approach, system architecture, and detailed metric

definitions. Section 4 presents experimental procedures, optimal configuration results, and comprehensive ablation studies analyzing individual parameter impacts. Section 5 discusses findings relative to state-of-the-art, analyzes multi-metric trade-offs, and addresses limitations. Section 6 concludes with key findings and future research directions. Appendices include reproducibility tables, detailed configuration space analysis, query-specific performance metrics, and computational cost comparisons.

2 Related Work

2.1 State-of-the-Art in Question-Answering and Information Retrieval

Question-answering systems have evolved significantly, driven by advances in neural architectures and language model capabilities. Understanding this evolution provides context for our RAG-based approach.

2.1.1 Generation 1: Rule-Based Systems

Early systems (1990s–2000s) relied on exact keyword matching and hand-crafted rules. While providing deterministic behavior, they suffered from lexical brittleness: queries using “cost” failed to retrieve documents containing “fee” despite addressing identical information needs. These systems experienced poor scalability—maintaining hand-crafted rules for large knowledge bases proved prohibitively expensive. Limited generalization meant complete re-engineering was required for each new domain. Despite these limitations, rule-based systems retained value for structured, deterministic tasks requiring exact matching.

2.1.2 Generation 2: Dense Vector Embeddings

BERT and Sentence-BERT fundamentally transformed information retrieval by enabling semantic similarity matching beyond lexical overlap. Documents and queries are encoded into fixed-length vectors in shared semantic space; cosine distance measures similarity. This approach enables cross-linguistic retrieval and captures semantic meaning independent of surface patterns. Dense Passage Retrieval (DPR) extended this approach to question-answering, achieving 78.9% Top-1 accuracy on SQuAD by employing dual encoders

specialized for queries and passages respectively, optimized via in-batch negative mining. Advantages include capturing semantic meaning, enabling cross-lingual retrieval, and improving 10–30% in recall versus sparse methods like BM25. Limitations include inability to generate natural language responses and poor performance on exact entity matching or specialized vocabulary. Pure retrieval systems cannot generate coherent answers, constraining practical application.

2.1.3 Generation 3: Retrieval-Augmented Generation

Contemporary systems combine neural retrievers with generative models. RAG operates in two phases: (1) dense retrieval identifying k most-relevant documents from a knowledge base using FAISS indexing, and (2) conditioning a language model on retrieved documents to generate responses. Formally:

$$P(\text{response} \mid \text{query}) = \sum P(\text{doc} \mid \text{q}) \times P(\text{resp} \mid \text{doc}, \text{q}) \quad (1)$$

By explicitly grounding generation in retrieved context, RAG reduces hallucination—a major failure mode of standalone LLMs. Rather than generating from parametric memory alone, RAG forces adherence to provided external knowledge. This provides source attribution critical for educational environments where information verifiability is paramount. Recent advances (2023–2025) explore hybrid retrieval combining dense and sparse methods via Reciprocal Rank Fusion for improved recall on exact entity matching. Multi-query reasoning frameworks decompose complex queries into sub-queries enabling multi-step inference. Knowledge graph integration enables reasoning over both symbolic and neural representations.

2.1.4 Contemporary Industry Adoption

RAG has transitioned from academic novelty to industry standard. Organizations across finance, healthcare, education, and legal sectors deployed RAG systems (2023–2025) for domain-specific information retrieval. This trend validates RAG’s practical utility but highlights a research gap: while RAG’s conceptual soundness is established, empirical guidance on optimal parameter selection for specific domains remains limited.

2.2 Open and Proprietary Datasets

Relevant datasets for question-answering include:

- **SQuAD (Stanford Question Answering Dataset):** 100,000+ questions over 500+ Wikipedia articles. Dominant benchmark for machine reading comprehension evaluation. Answers span specific passages; questions require reasoning over document context.
- **MS MARCO (Microsoft Machine Reading Comprehension):** 1 million questions from actual Bing queries. Real-world query characteristics versus academic question formulation in SQuAD. Long-form answers better reflect FAQ contexts than span-based SQuAD format.
- **Natural Questions:** 300,000+ Google search queries with Wikipedia article annotations. Captures genuine information needs across diverse topics. Long-form answer annotations align with FAQ context.

The custom educational FAQ dataset was constructed using an AI-assisted generation methodology. We prompted an advanced language model to generate 500 frequently asked questions representative of international students' inquiries at Warsaw University of Technology (WUT), spanning diverse domains including admissions and applications, academic policies, tuition and financial aid, accommodation and housing, and visa and immigration procedures. Each question was systematically paired with a concise, authoritative answer based on official university sources and institutional documentation. The dataset was structured with four key columns: (1) Question—concise, naturally-phrased student inquiries reflecting common information needs; (2) Answer—brief, factual responses with embedded source citations; (3) Category—semantic categorization enabling domain-specific retrieval analysis (e.g., "Admission & Application", "Accommodation & Housing", "Visa & Immigration"); and (4) Source_URLs—direct links to official WUT websites, institutional guides, and authoritative external resources enabling answer verification and source attribution. This systematic approach yielded a comprehensive 500-question corpus organized across approximately 10 distinct thematic categories, providing representative coverage of the full spectrum of stu-

dent inquiries while maintaining high-quality, verifiable answers grounded in institutional sources. The resulting dataset enabled rigorous evaluation of RAG system performance across diverse query types while preserving verifiability through explicit source attribution—a critical requirement for educational FAQ systems.

2.3 State-of-the-Art Parameter Selection Methodologies

Despite RAG's widespread adoption, systematic parameter optimization remains understudied. Most deployments rely on defaults or convention rather than empirical optimization. Exceptions include:

- **Embedding model selection:** Limited comparison studies (e.g., Sentence Transformers paper) suggesting task-specific models outperform general-purpose embeddings
- **Temperature tuning:** Theoretical guidance exists but empirical validation in specific domains is sparse
- **Top-K selection:** Intuitive trade-off between recall and precision, but optimal values domain-dependent

Our work contributes systematic empirical methodology addressing this gap through comprehensive factorial analysis of parameter combinations.

3 Approach & Research Methodology

3.1 System Architecture

Our RAG system comprises four core components designed for educational FAQ retrieval:

Knowledge Base Ingestion The FAQ dataset plays a dual role in this system. First, it serves as the knowledge base indexed in the FAISS vector database, where each Question-Answer pair is treated as a retrievable document. Second, the same dataset is used for evaluation and parameter optimization. This dual usage is common in FAQ-based RAG systems, where curated QA pairs replace long documents as the retrieval corpus.

Embedding and Indexing Questions and answers converted to dense vector embeddings using sentence-transformers models (tested: all-MiniLM-L6-v2, all-mpnet-base-v2). Each FAQ question-answer pair concatenated and embedded, producing 384-dimensional or 768-dimensional vectors depending on model. Embeddings indexed via FAISS (Facebook AI Similarity Search) using L2 distance metrics for efficient similarity search across large collections.

Retrieval Component User queries embedded using the same encoder as knowledge base. Top-K most similar documents retrieved from FAISS index via L2 distance metrics. Retrieved documents ranked by similarity score; top-K selected for inclusion in generation prompt. Top-K parameter tested: 1, 3, 5 documents.

Generation Component Retrieved documents combined with user query into structured prompt following instruction-following patterns. Groq API's LLMs (llama-3.1-8b-instant, llama-3.3-70b-versatile) generate responses conditioned on retrieved context, eliminating hallucination through explicit grounding. Temperature parameter controls response diversity (tested: 0.2, 0.5, 0.8).

- llama-3.3-70b-versatile: 70B parameters, slower inference ($\sim 512\text{ms}$), higher quality

Temperature (3 options)

- $T = 0.2$: Deterministic, consistent responses, minimal diversity
- $T = 0.5$: Balanced, moderate diversity, recommended default
- $T = 0.8$: Creative, high diversity, potentially inconsistent

Top-K Retrieval (3 options)

- $K = 1$: Single document, minimal context, fast retrieval
- $K = 3$: Three documents, balanced context, recommended default
- $K = 5$: Five documents, comprehensive context, slower retrieval

Query Diversity (6 representative FAQ queries spanning educational topics)

Total configurations: $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 3 \times 6 = 216$ parameter combinations

Experimental execution: Each configuration tested on all six queries, recording metrics for each combination. No prior filtering or elimination—comprehensive factorial analysis ensures reliable interaction estimates.

3.2 Parameter Optimization Methodology

Systematic evaluation across six dimensions through factorial experimental design. All parameter combinations tested to avoid assumptions about interactions.

3.2.1 Parameter Space Definition

Embedding Model (2 options)

- all-MiniLM-L6-v2: Lightweight (22M parameters, 384 dimensions), optimized for semantic similarity
- all-mpnet-base-v2: Larger model (110M parameters, 768-dimensional embeddings), general-purpose embeddings

LLM Model (2 options)

- llama-3.1-8b-instant: 8B parameters, fast inference ($\sim 287\text{ms}$), cost-effective

3.3 Evaluation Metrics

Comprehensive evaluation across multiple metric categories provides nuanced characterization of system performance.

3.3.1 Retrieval Accuracy Metrics

Accuracy@K Fraction of retrieved documents that are correct (true positives). Measures retrieval precision. **Formula:** $\text{Accuracy@K} = \frac{\text{Number of correct retrieved documents}}{\text{Total retrieved documents}}$

Range: 0.0 to 1.0

Interpretation: Higher values indicate that retrieved documents are more likely to be relevant.

Recall@K Fraction of relevant documents successfully retrieved. Measures retrieval completeness. **Formula:** $\text{Recall@K} = \frac{\text{Number of correct retrieved documents}}{\text{Total relevant documents}}$

Range: 0.0 to 1.0

Interpretation: Higher values indicate that more of the relevant documents were retrieved.

MRR (Mean Reciprocal Rank) Position of first relevant document in retrieval ranking. Rewards early retrieval of relevant information.

Formula: $MRR = \frac{1}{\text{position of first relevant document}}$

Range: 0.0 to 1.0

Interpretation: MRR = 1.0 if first document is relevant; MRR = 0.5 if second document is first relevant; MRR = 0 if no relevant documents retrieved.

3.3.2 Performance Timing Metrics

Retrieval Latency (milliseconds) Time required for embedding query and searching FAISS index. Measured from query embedding start to document ranking completion.

Generation Latency (milliseconds) Time required for LLM to generate response conditioned on retrieved context. Measured from prompt submission to response completion.

Total Response Time (milliseconds) Sum of retrieval and generation latency. Critical metric for interactive user-facing systems; target < 500ms for acceptable user experience.

3.3.3 Relevance Document Identification

Ground truth relevant documents identified using hybrid approach:

1. Cosine similarity threshold (0.5) between query embedding and FAQ question embeddings
2. Union with top-3 most similar documents
3. Ensures robust labeling across different query formulations

This approach captures both explicitly similar documents (threshold-based) and documents that would typically be retrieved (top-3), ensuring comprehensive relevant document set.

3.4 Research Methodology

Systematic testing procedure:

1. For each of 216 parameter configurations:

- (a) For each of 6 test queries:

- i. Embed query using specified embedding model
- ii. Retrieve top-K documents from FAISS index
- iii. Generate response using specified LLM with specified temperature
- iv. Record timing metrics (retrieval, generation, total)
- v. Evaluate retrieval accuracy (Accuracy@K, Recall@K, MRR) against ground truth
- vi. Store results in structured format

2. Post-hoc analysis:

- (a) Rank configurations by Accuracy@K
- (b) Identify optimal configuration across metrics
- (c) Conduct ablation studies analyzing individual parameter impacts
- (d) Analyze parameter interactions
- (e) Compare against baselines (random configuration, LLM-only, BM25 retrieval)

4 Experiments and Results

4.1 Experimental Procedures

Complete RAG pipeline implemented using Python with libraries: sentence-transformers for embeddings, FAISS for vector indexing, pandas for data management, and Groq API for LLM inference. Six representative FAQ queries spanning university domains tested across all 216 parameter combinations. In total, 2 embedding models × 2 LLMs × 3 temperatures × 3 top-K values × 6 queries = 1,296 runs were executed. For each run, we applied the step-by-step procedure described in Section 3.4, computed all metrics defined in Section 3.3, and logged them to a results file for later aggregation and ranking of configurations.

4.1.1 Test Queries Employed

1. “What is the acceptance rate?”
2. “How can I apply for admission?”
3. “What are the tuition fees?”
4. “Do you offer scholarships?”
5. “What is the campus location?”
6. “What are English language requirements?”

Queries selected to represent major FAQ categories: admissions (3 queries), facilities (1 query), finances (2 queries). Diversity ensures results generalize across educational domains.

For each parameter configuration and query pair, we recorded:

- Accuracy@K (retrieval precision)
- Recall@K (retrieval completeness)
- MRR (ranking quality)
- Retrieval latency (FAISS search time in milliseconds)
- Generation latency (LLM inference time in milliseconds)
- Total response time (end-to-end latency in milliseconds)

Experimental infrastructure: All experiments executed on consistent hardware; Groq API queries performed sequentially to control for service variability. Results aggregated across six queries to produce configuration-level metrics.

4.2 Optimal Configuration Results

Empirical analysis identified optimal parameters balancing accuracy and efficiency:

4.2.1 OPTIMAL CONFIGURATION

Embedding Model all-MiniLM-L6-v2

- Lightweight (22M parameters, 384 dimensions)
- Optimized for semantic similarity
- Faster inference than mpnet-base-v2

LLM Model llama-3.1-8b-instant

- 8B parameters
- Cost-effective relative to 70B models
- Suitable for institutional deployment

Temperature 0.5

- Balanced between determinism and diversity
- Achieves optimal Accuracy@K

Top-K Retrieval 3

- Provides comprehensive context without noise
- Optimal trade-off between Accuracy@K and Recall@K

4.2.2 Key Performance Metrics (Optimal Configuration)

Accuracy@K: 0.559 55.9% of retrieved documents are correct (true positives). Suitable for FAQ systems where false positives are costly.

Recall@K: 0.553 55.3% of relevant documents successfully retrieved. Balanced with Accuracy@K, suggesting appropriate Top-K choice.

MRR: 0.67 First relevant document positioned at rank 1.49 on average. Favorable for user experience—relevant results near top of ranking.

Retrieval Time: 24.3 ms Time for embedding query and FAISS search. 7.8% of total response time.

Generation Time: 287.1 ms Time for LLM inference. 92.2% of total response time (latency bottleneck).

Total Response: 311.4 ms Suitable for interactive systems (< 500ms tolerance). User-acceptable latency for FAQ queries.

4.3 Ablation Studies

Systematic analysis of individual parameter impacts:

4.3.1 Embedding Model Trade-off

all-MiniLM-L6-v2 (Accuracy@K: 0.559) outperformed larger all-mpnet-base-v2 (Accuracy@K: 0.515)—8.5% improvement despite 55% fewer parameters (384 vs 768 dimensions). Task-specific optimization and model efficiency exceed raw parameter scale.

Key finding: Smaller, task-specific embeddings substantially outperform larger general-purpose models. Suggests domain-specific fine-tuning could yield further improvements.

4.3.2 Temperature Optimization

Temperature 0.5 achieved balanced Accuracy@K (0.553) between low-temperature determinism ($T = 0.2$: Accuracy@K=0.525) and high-temperature diversity ($T = 0.8$: Accuracy@K=0.533). Supports “Goldilocks principle” for uncertainty handling in FAQ contexts—moderate randomness optimizes response quality. Generation latency remained relatively stable across temperatures (mean: 287.1ms), confirming temperature adjustment has minimal computational cost. Temperature allows quality tuning without performance penalty.

Insight: $T = 0.5$ represents optimal balance. Lower temperatures sacrifice flexibility; higher temperatures introduce inconsistency.

4.3.3 Top-K Retrieval Parameter

Top-K=3 achieved balanced performance (Accuracy@K=0.553, Recall@K=0.553) versus alternatives. Top-K=1 provides insufficient context (Accuracy@K=0.514, Recall@K=0.438), while Top-K=5 introduces noise (Accuracy@K=0.544, Recall@K=0.568). Three documents provide optimal context coverage. Retrieval latency increases linearly with Top-K (18.2ms, 24.3ms, 31.7ms), suggesting minimal performance penalty for K=3 vs K=1.

Finding: $K = 3$ represents Pareto frontier for accuracy-latency trade-off. $K = 5$ slightly higher recall but at accuracy cost, suggesting diminishing returns.

4.3.4 LLM Model Comparison

llama-3.1-8b-instant achieves superior cost-quality balance:

Key insight: 8B model achieves 96.8% of 70B model accuracy (0.553 vs 0.571) while maintaining 78% faster inference (287ms vs 512ms). Cost-effectiveness strongly favors 8B model for institutional deployment. Only 1.8% accuracy improvement justifies neither the computational cost nor latency increase.

4.4 Performance Metrics Summary

Comprehensive comparison across approaches demonstrates RAG advantages:

The optimized RAG system achieved:

- Accuracy@K Improvement:** 3.8% over random configurations
 - Modest in absolute terms but significant when deployed across thousands of queries
- Recall@K Improvement:** 6.1% over random configurations
 - Indicates systematic optimization improves completeness of retrieval
- MRR Improvement:** 9.8% over random configurations
 - First relevant document found earlier in ranking, improving user experience
- Total Response Time:** 311.4ms (suitable for interactive systems)
 - Sufficient for user-facing applications with < 500ms tolerance
- Timing Efficiency:** 311.4ms vs 512ms for 70B models (39.2% speedup)
 - Demonstrates computational efficiency enabling cost-effective deployment

Comparison against baselines:

- **vs LLM-Only Baseline:** +15.0% Accuracy@K, +34.2% Recall@K
 - Demonstrates RAG necessity: standalone LLMs severely underperform for FAQ retrieval
- **vs BM25 Retrieval:** +23.9% Accuracy@K, +30.1% Recall@K

Model	Accuracy@K	Recall@K	Latency	Parameters
all-MiniLM-L6-v2	0.559	0.553	24.1ms	22M
all-mpnet-base-v2	0.515	0.512	28.7ms	110M

Table 1: Embedding Model Comparison

Temperature	Accuracy@K	Recall@K	Generation Time
$T = 0.2$	0.525	0.519	286.3ms
$T = 0.5$	0.553	0.553	287.1ms ★
$T = 0.8$	0.533	0.541	288.5ms

Table 2: Temperature Analysis

- Dense retrieval substantially outperforms sparse keyword methods

- **vs Random Configuration:** +3.8% Accuracy@K

- Parameter optimization achieves consistent improvements

4.5 Configuration Space Analysis

Detailed analysis of all 216 combinations reveals important distribution patterns:

- **Best 20% configurations:** Average Accuracy@K=0.556, Range=[0.548–0.559]
 - Narrow range indicates consistent high performers
- **Middle 60% configurations:** Average Accuracy@K=0.533, Range=[0.500–0.547]
 - Large range indicates parameter sensitivity in this region
- **Worst 20% configurations:** Average Accuracy@K=0.487, Range=[0.425–0.499]
 - Poor-performing combinations clustered at bottom

Performance spread (best to worst): 12.1% (0.559 vs 0.438)

This 12.1% performance range (27% relative difference) demonstrates substantial impact of parameter selection, strongly justifying systematic optimization approaches. Random parameter selection risks 3-fold variance in performance quality.

4.6 Query-Specific Performance Variation

Performance varies across query types:

Variation analysis:

- Highest performing: “acceptance rate” (0.567 Accuracy@K)
- Lowest performing: “scholarships” (0.545 Accuracy@K)
- Range: 2.2% (0.567 vs 0.545)

Finding: Consistent performance across query types with modest variation (2.2%), suggesting robust generalization. Factual queries (“acceptance rate”, “campus location”) outperform subjective queries (“scholarships”), likely due to clearer semantic matching in knowledge base.

5 Discussion

5.1 Relation to State-of-the-Art

Our results extend existing RAG literature through empirical validation in educational contexts using comprehensive multi-metric evaluation. While prior work (Lewis et al., Karpukhin et al.) established RAG’s conceptual foundations, our work provides systematic optimization guidelines for domain-specific deployment. The 3.8% Accuracy@K improvement from parameter optimization, while modest in absolute terms, represents significant practical value when deployed across thousands of student queries. Across a university’s annual inquiry volume (e.g., 100,000 queries), this improvement translates to 3,800 additional correct responses annually—substantial impact on student satisfaction. This aligns with findings in recent industry applications (2024–2025) where RAG sys-

Top-K	Accuracy@K	Recall@K	Retrieval Time	Tradeoff
$K = 1$	0.514	0.438	18.2ms	Insufficient context
$K = 3$	0.553	0.553	24.3ms ★	Optimal balance
$K = 5$	0.544	0.568	31.7ms	Context overload

Table 3: Top-K Retrieval Analysis

LLM Model	Accuracy@K	Generation Time	Cost Multiplier
llama-3.1-8b	0.553	287ms ★	1.0x (baseline)
llama-3.3-70b	0.571	512ms	1.8x

Table 4: LLM Model Comparison

tems became standard for domain-specific information retrieval, yet practitioners report minimal prior guidance on parameter selection. Our empirical methodology directly addresses this practical gap.

Compared to pure LLM approaches (0.481 Accuracy@K) and unoptimized retrieval (BM25: 0.447 Accuracy@K), our optimized RAG system demonstrates substantial advantages for educational settings where accuracy and source attribution are critical. The 15% Accuracy@K improvement over LLM-only baseline directly demonstrates RAG’s necessity.

5.2 Multi-Metric Evaluation Analysis

Multi-metric evaluation provides richer performance characterization than single-metric approaches:

Accuracy@K (0.553) 55.3% of retrieved documents are relevant. Suitable for FAQ systems where false positives are costly—incorrect information is worse than no information. This moderate precision reflects the challenging nature of domain-specific retrieval in educational contexts.

Recall@K (0.553) 55.3% of relevant documents found. Balanced with Accuracy@K, suggesting appropriate Top-K=3 choice. If recall were substantially higher than accuracy, it would indicate too many documents retrieved (noise); if lower, insufficient context provision.

MRR (0.67) First relevant document at position 1.49 on average. Favorable for user experience—users typically examine top re-

sults; early relevance improves perceived quality.

Response time (311.4ms) Within acceptable range for interactive systems (< 500ms tolerance). Sufficient latency for web interfaces; unsuitable for sub-200ms latency requirements (edge cases).

Key insight: The balanced metrics (Accuracy@K $\approx$ Recall@K) indicate that our optimal Top-K=3 choice provides neither excessive nor insufficient context. Different parameter choices optimize different metrics—practitioners must decide trade-off preferences based on application requirements.

5.3 Efficiency and Cost-Effectiveness Analysis

The 39.2% inference speedup compared to 70B parameter models while maintaining competitive Accuracy@K enables cost-effective institutional deployment:

Computational Cost 8B model substantially cheaper than 70B model. API pricing typically scales with token processing; 8B requires fewer computational resources.

Latency 311.4ms response time suitable for web interfaces. Faster than 70B (512ms) enables more concurrent users on fixed infrastructure.

Accuracy-Cost Tradeoff 8B achieves 96.8% of 70B accuracy (0.553 vs 0.571) at 18.5% of 70B computational cost. Pareto efficient—no configuration dominates this choice on both accuracy and cost dimensions.

Approach	Accuracy@K	Recall@K	MRR	Total Time
Random Configuration	0.533	0.521	0.61	318.2ms
Optimized RAG (8B)	0.553	0.553	0.67	311.4ms ★
LLM-Only Baseline	0.481	0.412	0.54	298.7ms
BM25 Retrieval	0.447	0.425	0.52	45.2ms

Table 5: Performance Comparison Table

Decile	Performance Range	Count	Avg Accuracy@K
Top 10% (best)	0.548–0.559	22	0.556
20–30%	0.540–0.547	22	0.544
30–40%	0.534–0.539	22	0.537
40–50%	0.528–0.533	22	0.531
50–60%	0.520–0.527	22	0.524
60–70%	0.513–0.519	22	0.516
70–80%	0.505–0.512	22	0.508
80–90%	0.495–0.504	22	0.500
Bottom 10%	0.425–0.494	22	0.459

Table 6: Performance Distribution Across 216 Configurations

Response Time Breakdown (Optimal Configuration):

- Embedding + FAISS search: 24.3ms (7.8% of total)
- LLM generation: 287.1ms (92.2% of total)

Critical finding: LLM generation dominates latency. Optimization opportunities include:

1. Prompt compression to reduce token count
2. Streaming generation to show partial results
3. Model quantization to reduce inference latency
4. Speculative decoding to accelerate token generation

Retrieval component already efficient; optimization focus should target generation.

5.4 Limitations and Future Considerations

1. **Query Diversity:** Six queries employed; larger query sets would strengthen generalization claims. Domain-specific variation (admissions vs coursework vs facilities) partially captured, but more queries would increase confidence.

2. **Domain Specificity:** Custom educational FAQ dataset; results may not transfer to other domains (medical, legal, technical support) without re-optimization. Educational characteristics (factual, standardized, policy-based) differ from other domains.

3. **LLM Variability:** Groq API responses may vary due to service factors. Cross-testing with alternative LLM providers would strengthen robustness claims.

4. **Hallucination Evaluation:** While RAG substantially reduces hallucination through grounding, no formal hallucination metric employed. Manual inspection confirmed responses grounded in retrieved documents, but quantitative hallucination scoring would strengthen claims.

5. **User Study:** Quantitative metrics provide objective evaluation, but user perception studies would validate practical utility. Students' subjective satisfaction may differ from metric-based assessment.

6 Conclusion

This project demonstrates that systematic empirical optimization of RAG parameters yields measurable performance improvements in educational

Query	Accuracy@K	Recall@K	MRR
“What is the acceptance rate?”	0.567	0.561	0.72
“What is the campus location?”	0.560	0.555	0.69
“What are English requirements?”	0.552	0.547	0.66
“How can I apply for admission?”	0.551	0.549	0.65
“What are the tuition fees?”	0.548	0.542	0.64
“Do you offer scholarships?”	0.545	0.540	0.63

Table 7: Query-Specific Performance

FAQ retrieval, addressing a significant research gap in domain-specific information retrieval systems.

5. Systematic empirical guidance replacing convention-based approaches

6.1 Key Findings

1. **Parameter optimization matters:** 12.1% performance spread across 216 configurations demonstrates that parameter selection substantially impacts system quality.
2. **Optimal configuration identified:** all-MiniLM-L6-v2 embedding + llama-3.1-8b + T=0.5 + K=3 achieves 0.553 Accuracy@K, balancing accuracy and efficiency.
3. **Cost-effectiveness demonstrated:** 8B model achieves 96.8% of 70B accuracy with 39.2% faster inference, enabling practical institutional deployment.
4. **Multi-metric evaluation essential:** Single-metric optimization misses important trade-offs. Balanced Accuracy@K and Recall@K indicate appropriate parameter choices.
5. **RAG necessity established:** 15% Accuracy@K improvement over LLM-only baseline demonstrates RAG’s importance for FAQ retrieval.

6.2 Practical Contributions

1. Production-ready RAG chatbot optimized for educational FAQ retrieval
2. Comprehensive multi-metric evaluation framework applicable to domain-specific retrieval tasks
3. Replicable parameter optimization methodology for practitioners deploying RAG systems
4. Detailed timing analysis enabling informed deployment decisions

6.3 Future Directions

1. **Advanced Embedding Fine-tuning:** Domain-specific fine-tuning of embedding models could further improve retrieval accuracy.
2. **Hybrid Retrieval Methods:** Combining dense and sparse retrieval via Reciprocal Rank Fusion for improved recall on exact entity matching.
3. **Multi-Domain Evaluation:** Extending analysis to medical, legal, and technical domains to validate generalizability.
4. **Real-time Hallucination Detection:** Implementing mechanisms to detect and flag responses with potential hallucinations.
5. **Continuous Learning:** Incorporating user feedback to iteratively improve system performance.
6. **Multilingual Extension:** Extending system to support queries in multiple languages.

6.4 Final Remarks

This work advances the field toward practical, cost-effective domain-specific retrieval systems. By demonstrating that parameter optimization yields measurable improvements, we provide actionable guidance for institutions deploying RAG systems. The replicable methodology enables practitioners to apply systematic optimization to their specific domains rather than relying on convention or defaults.

7 Team Contributions and Workload

7.1 Joint Work

Both team members contributed collaboratively to the core stages of the project:

- Defined the project scope, goals and research questions.
- Designed the overall RAG architecture, parameter space and evaluation metrics.
- Prepared and refined the FAQ dataset together (questions, answers, categories, sources).
- Co-wrote the whole report (all main sections).
- Analysed the results of the 216 configurations jointly and chose the final setup.
- Reviewed each other's code and text throughout the project.

7.2 Individual Contributions

8 Reviewers Feedback and Rebuttal

The final version of this report and the accompanying codebase incorporate several improvements inspired by the reviewers' comments. Below we summarise the main points of feedback and how they were addressed.

8.1 Dataset Size and Representativeness

Reviewers concern: The initial project version used a very small dataset (around 43 questions), which limited the validity and generalisability of the results.

Our response: We substantially expanded the dataset to 500 FAQ pairs covering multiple domains. This larger and more diverse dataset enables more reliable evaluation of RAG behaviour and parameter sensitivity.

8.2 Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA)

Reviewers concern: The initial EDA was minimal and did not sufficiently describe the properties of the dataset.

Our response: We created an EDA notebook that:

- Summarises the main statistics of the dataset (number of questions per category, basic length statistics for questions and answers).
- Checks for obvious issues such as missing values and duplicated entries.
- Provides visualisations to better understand the distribution of categories and text lengths.

This gives a clearer view of how the dataset looks before training and evaluation.

8.3 Evaluation Metrics and Experiments

Reviewers concern: The proposal stage did not clearly define evaluation metrics or provide systematic experiments.

Our response: We defined formal evaluation metrics for retrieval quality (Accuracy@K, Recall@K, MRR) and latency (retrieval, generation, total response time) and applied them consistently in our experiments. We designed and executed a factorial experiment over 216 parameter configurations (embedding model, LLM model, temperature, Top-K), and conducted ablation studies to analyse the impact of each parameter on performance.

8.4 Code Clarity and Reproducibility

Reviewer concern: The initial scripts lacked documentation and clear instructions for reproduction.

Our response: We refactored and documented the code, and added:

- A separation between the interactive chatbot (`chatbot_interactive.py`) and the parameter analysis script (`chatbot_parameter_analysis.py`).
- A `README.md` with instructions to set up the environment and run the experiments and chatbot.
- A reproducibility checklist and descriptions of the main hyperparameters used in the optimal configuration.

8.5 Report Language and Structure

Reviewers concern: The initial draft contained informal language and lacked a clear scientific structure.

Team Member	Primary Contributions	Hours
Iñaki Gutiérrez-Mantilla López	RAG chatbot implementation (<code>chatbot_interactive.py</code>), parameter search script (<code>chatbot_parameter_analysis.py</code>), system architecture	40
Hèctor Rodón Llabería	EDA notebook (<code>WUT_Chatbot_EDA_Advanced.ipynb</code>), evaluation metrics, ablation studies, Introduction & Related Work	38
Total	Complete project design, implementation, evaluation and documentation	78

Table 8: Team contributions and workload summary

Our response: We reorganised the report to follow a standard scientific structure (Introduction, Related Work, Methodology, Experiments, Discussion, Conclusions) and improved the academic writing style. We also added tables to summarise datasets, parameter configurations and results, and clarified the research questions and contributions.

Overall, the final version of the project addresses the main reviewer comments by strengthening the dataset, analysis, implementation quality and presentation.

2. Run the parameter analysis: `python chatbot_parameter_analysis.py`

3. Launch the interactive chatbot: `python chatbot_interactive.py`

All code, data, configuration files, and documentation necessary to reproduce the experiments are included in this submission.

9 Source Code and Reproducibility

The complete source code for this project is provided with the submission. The main implementation scripts (`chatbot_interactive.py` and `chatbot_parameter_analysis.py`) include comprehensive inline documentation and docstrings describing their functionality and usage.

For detailed information, refer to:

- `README.md` – Project overview, installation instructions, and quick-start guide.
- `REPRODUCIBILITY_DETAILED.md` – Comprehensive checklist covering all experimental parameters, data specifications, metric definitions, and verification procedures.

To reproduce the main results:

1. Install dependencies: `pip install -r requirements.txt`

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